

THE DALAI LAMA

A TIGHTROPE WALK

Nowhere are the aftershocks of the riots in Lhasa more visible than at Mcleodganj in Himachal Pradesh, the seat of the Tibetan government-in-exile. Fresh graffiti on the walls and banners with slogans such as "Free Tibet", "Stop genocide in Tibet", "Wake up, UN" have sprung all over the town, with occasional sloganeering by defiant marchers. Such carefully-orchestrated protests now form the centrepiece of the plans of the Tibetan government-in-exile to keep the Lhasa unrest on the front burner of international concerns in the run-up to the 2008 Beijing Olympics. Also for the 50th anniversary next year of the failed Tibetan uprising that had forced the Dalai Lama, the Tibetan spiritual leader, and his followers to flee Tibet and take shelter in India in 1959.

A war of words between the Chinese Government and the Dalai Lama has escalated with the Nobel laureate charging Beijing with "cultural genocide" in Tibet. The Chinese riposte was sharp and they belligerently called the Dalai Lama the "mastermind" behind the recent Lhasa violence.

Stung, the Dalai Lama first pooh-poohed the Chinese for making him a "scapegoat" and, later, offered to step down as the chief proponent of the Tibetan cause if his community resorted to any sort of violence in their peaceful protests—a well-thought-out move to checkmate the Chinese propaganda and to re-assert his high moral ground in the eyes of the international community. "My community in Tibet is like a deer in the clutches of a tiger. It's agitated but utterly helpless," he said, seeking an international probe into the crackdown.

Even as the Dalai Lama has reiterated his avowed moderate "middle-way approach" that seeks "genuine autonomy for Tibet while being a part of China", he is under growing pressure from hardliners in his commu-

nity to keep up the momentum of the agitation sparked by the Lhasa riots. The Dalai Lama faces an unenviable tightrope walk on his pacifist approach and an overriding task of making the Tibetan community rally behind his agenda.

Not surprisingly, the Tibetan government-in-exile has been quick to script a 'strike-when-the-iron-is-hot' strategy ahead of the Olympics, hoping it would bring about renewed international pressure on China to enter into a "structured dialogue" with the Dalai Lama on his demand for "genuine autonomy" within the Chinese territorial framework. "We will keep up the tempo of worldwide protests to force China to shun its repressive policies in Tibet and come to the negotiating table," prime minister of the Tibetan government-in-exile, Samdhong Rinpoche, told INDIA TODAY. "The Lhasa flare-up has lent an urgency to the need for addressing the moderate aspirations of the Tibetans," he added.

But Beijing is unlikely to move beyond the "token" offers for a dialogue on the restive region. In fact, it has been following a carrot-and-stick approach in engaging the Dalai Lama's envoys since 2002—widely seen as a ploy to negate the international pressure for dialogue on the spiritual leader's middle-way agenda.

But the Chinese negotiators' insistence on the Dalai Lama first declaring Tibet an inalienable part of China even before 1951 and shunning his demand for autonomy for the entire Tibet region proved to be a stumbling block in the failed meeting. "We are demanding genuine autonomy and not separation but the Chinese leadership has shown no spirit of accommodation," says Rinpoche. While Beijing may have put down Lhasa, in the months ahead the Tibetans in exile will step up the tempo of their protests.

by Ramesh Vinayak in Mcleodganj



EYE OF THE STORM: The Dalai Lama speaks to the media at Dharamshala; a video grab shows violent demonstrations on a Lhasa street (below)

